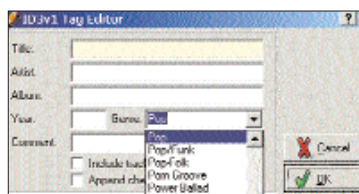


### Kailas Shastry

**A**lmost every gadget available today can be used with little or no calibration. But getting your hands dirty with details and feature sets is what separates the boys from the geeks. An MP3 player is no exception. Of course you can simply drag and drop or use a syncing software to transfer your songs. But there are optimisations that you can try out to make music listening a more pleasurable experience.

### Sort So You Can Search

Most players display files according to the filename—you will have files called track001.mp3 if that's how your ripping software names them. On Winamp or Windows Media Player, this is not a problem as they identify ID3 tags (bearing artist and album information) and not to mention, the easy navigation. Your MP3 player, even if it recognizes ID3 tags, will display the artist and title, but the sorting may not always be according to the tag. It gets irritating if you are looking for one particular song amongst a 100. A simple solution is to name the tracks with something more descriptive than an uninformative track001!

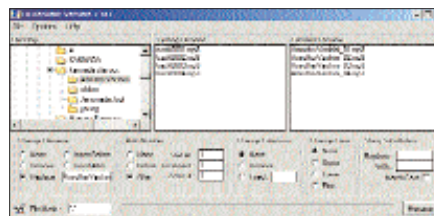


Setting ID3 tags in Audigrabber

While ripping from your CDs, set the preferences in your ripping software to name the files starting with a word that describes them, like the album or

artist name. If your ripping software does not have the option, spend a couple of minutes in renaming the MP3s manually.

Let's briefly take a look at a batch renaming software called CKRename. It gives you a variety



Batch renaming in CKRename

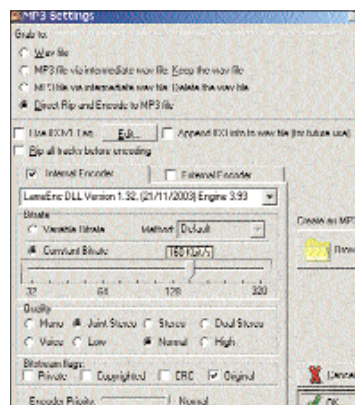
of options, like prefixing, suffixing, selective renaming etc. Download it from [www.music-sucks.com/CKSoft/CKRename/](http://www.music-sucks.com/CKSoft/CKRename/)

When you open CKRename you will see a Windows Explorer like interface to the left. Navigate to the folder whose files you wish to rename. You can change the filenames and extension, introduce numbering for the selected files. Files such as track001.mp3 can be changed to "artist-song name 001.mp3". You can later on rename them to "artist-song name.mp3" if you want to. You will be saved the trouble of typing in the artist's name for every song.

### Size vs Quality

In a really nice world, we will choose the best quality for our songs while ripping, in an ideal world we will just save them in the gigantic wave formats. But when we have to only so much space and a lot of songs—we will have to compress them. This holds good not only for MP3 players but any storage media, including hard disks. Most players support playback of MP3s compressed with 32 to 320 kbps. A higher bit rate provides better sound but occupies more space. For pure voice tracks, the basic

32 Kbps is enough to retain clarity. For music files however, compressing to 32 Kbps is criminal! You need 128 Kbps to retain the varied music elements. This will give you a file size of 1 MB per minute approximately. The 'quality' will also depend on the efficiencies of the ripping (encoding) software as well as the player itself. When both of these are good, you might just be able to get away with 96 kbps. We recommend 128 Kbps as a minimum however.



Setting the bitrate

Let us now take a look at ripping CDs using a well known free software called Audigrabber. Download it from <http://audiograber.com-us.net/download.html>.

Also download the LAME MP3 encoder from the same location and paste the lame\_enc.dll in the directory where audigrabber is installed.

When Audigrabber is opened, click on the button that says MP3 and choose the LameEnc DLL encoder. Set the quality settings to 'Joint Stereo' and 'High'. Now by moving the slider, choose the bit rate you want. For an MP3 player, you can start with 192 Kbps and go